PIA3123
THEORIES of DEVELOPMENT

WEEK 4 HUMAN DEVELOPMENT AND SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

BY FRANCESCA CHIU

Today's Lecture

1. Human development approach: Basic Needs and Capabilities Approach
2. Sustainable development: History and Trends
3. Break
4. Discussion
5. Conclusion



Is Development More Than GDP?

Have we been too focused on mainstream development approaches — those centered on economic growth and national aggregates?

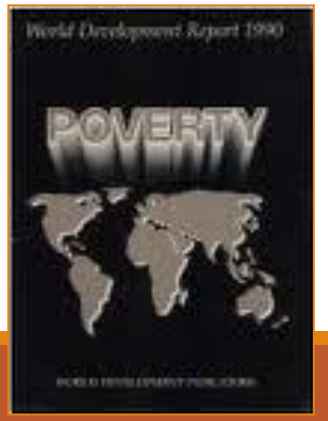
Are we defining development too narrowly, reducing it to income and production instead of people's well-being and freedoms?

Basic Needs Approach

- Ideas picked up first, by the International Labour Organisation, and later, by the World Bank
- The ILO (1976) *Employment, Growth and Basic Needs: A One World problem* set out the parameters of the early basic needs approach and defined basic needs as 'the minimum standard of living which a society should set for the poorest groups of its people'.



ILO (1976) above and World Bank (1990) below



Basic Needs Theory

- Required basic necessities, public goods and political participation
- Placed obligations on states which were not entirely appreciated among Third World governments
- Basic Needs theorists argued that basic needs are both **physical** - minimum levels of calorie consumption for example - as well as **intangible**, what Sen was to call 'agency achievements' - of participation, empowerment and community life
- So, growth-based models of development flawed; redistributive models include both income and intangibles

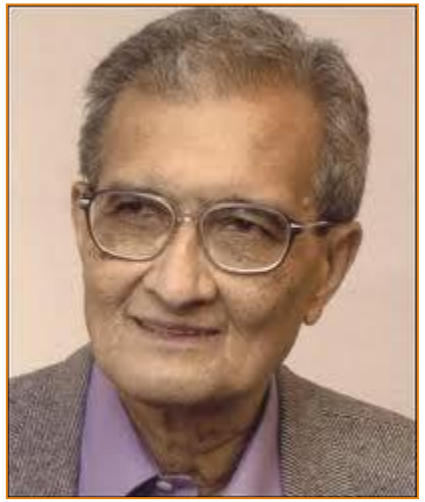
What causes famines? Natural disasters? Or human actions?



Link: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=amV_XKaiTKE

Capabilities Approach

- Amartya Sen's and Martha Nussbaum's work built on but moved beyond an understanding of basic human needs to a discussion of the required **entitlements** for the development of these **capabilities**.
- Sen defines entitlements as 'the set of alternative commodity bundles that a person can command in a society using the totality of rights and opportunities that he or she faces'.



Amartya Sen
(1933–) Indian economist



Martha Nussbaum
(1947 -) US philosopher

Sen and Capabilities

- **Human poverty exists when there is a deprivation of capability**
- A person's capability to live a good life is defined in terms of the set of valuable 'beings and doings' which are accessible to them. (eg: being in good health, or doings - such as employment or other economic activity.)
- Capabilities are substantive freedoms that allows people to be who they want to be and what they want to do
- **The Capability Theory placed significant emphasis on an individual's ability to achieve the kind of life they value as opposed to acquisition of commodities.**

Amartya Sen: Development as Freedom

- In *Development as Freedom*, Sen redefines development as the process of expanding the real freedoms the people enjoy.
- Freedom is both the means and the ends of development; freedom is not a byproduct of development
- Sen classifies freedoms into:
  - Political freedoms;
  - Economic facilities;
  - Social opportunities;
  - Transparency guarantees; and
  - Protective security.

Evolution of Basic Needs and Capabilities Theory

- **Introduction of gender relations and gender justice:**

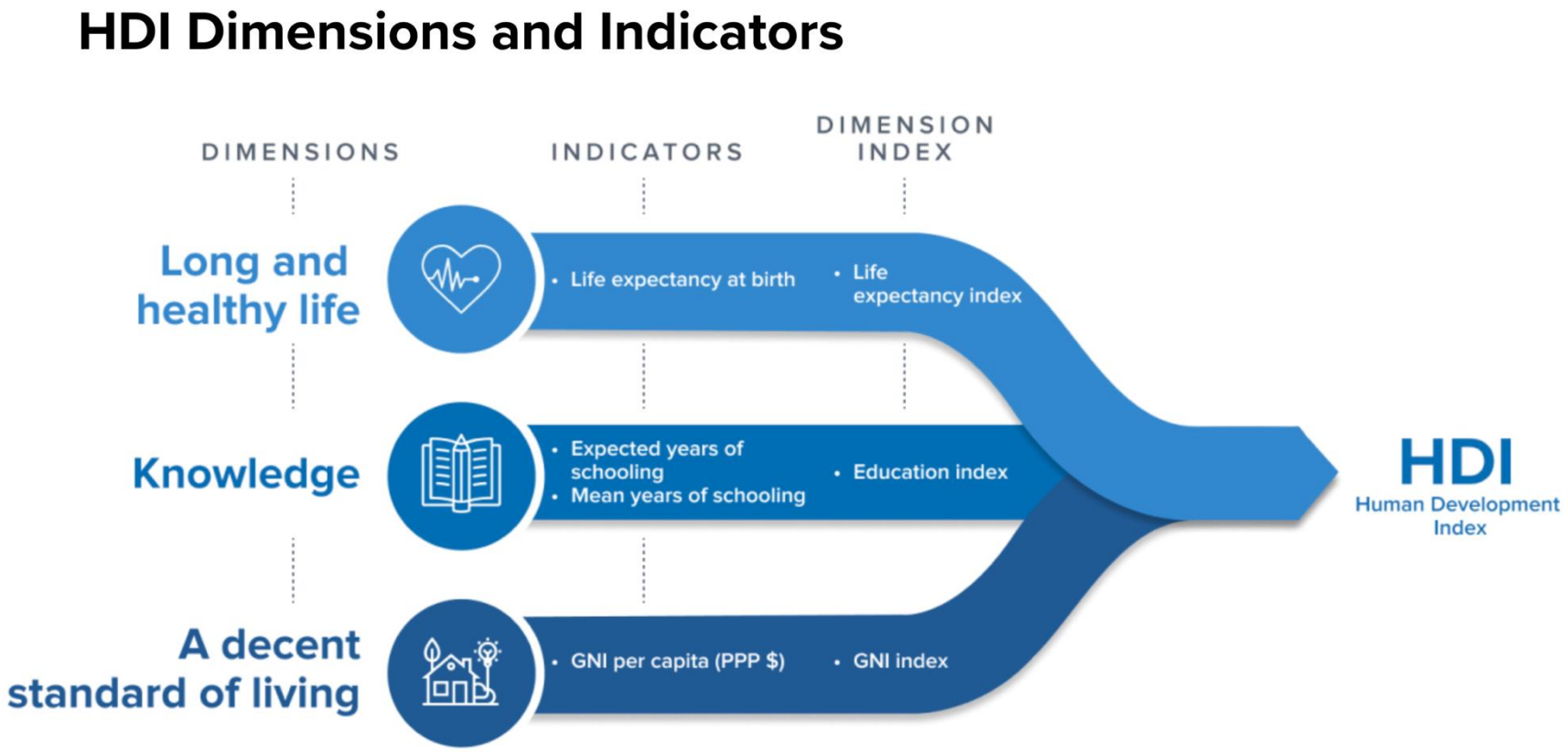
Expansion to include quality of gender relations and gender justice into capabilities theory: Martha Nussbaum sought to define the various capabilities "required" for a high quality of life.

This led to the realisation that gender was a key determinant of the quality of life leading to further analysis of gender relations and development of gender specific development measures.

- **Human Development approach:**

The basic needs and capabilities theories and Sen's freedoms theory laid the foundation for the Human Development Approach and led to development of the (UNDP) Human Development Report and Index.

Human Development Index (HDI)



The Millennium Development Goals (MDGs)

- UNDP meets World Bank
- Influence of heterodox economists visible
- Project time frame: 2000-2015



Did we achieve the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs)?

Our World in Data

Summary of global progress of the United Nations' (UN) Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), which spanned the period 2000-2015. Shown are the Targets of the MDGs*, levels in the baseline year, the final target level and actual achieved level for each Target.

— Achieved Targets are marked in **green**;
— Missed Targets are marked in **red**.

Millennium Development Goal (MDG) Target	Baseline level	Target level	Achieved final level
MDG1.A: halve share of people living in extreme poverty (<$1.25 per day)	47% in developing regions	Reduce to 23.5%	Fell to 14%
MDG1.B: achieve full and productive employment, as well as decent work for all, including young people and women	62% global working-age population in employment	Full (100%)	Fell to 60%
MDG1.C: halve the proportion of individuals suffering from hunger	23.3% in developing regions	Reduce to 11.5%	Fell to 12.9%
MDG2.A: ensure that children universally – including both boys and girls – will be able to complete a full course of primary education	83% in developing regions	Universal (100%)	Increased to 91%
MDG3.A: eliminate gender disparity at all education levels	Developing regions: 0.87 in primary 0.77 in secondary 0.71 in tertiary	Gender parity index (GPI) between 0.97-1.03	Developing regions: 0.98 in primary 0.98 in secondary 1.01 in tertiary
MDG4.A: reduce the under-five mortality rate by two-thirds	90 per 1,000 live births	Reduce to 30 per 1,000	Fell to 43 per 1,000
MDG5.A: reduce the maternal mortality ratio by 75 percent	380 per 100,000 births	Reduce to 95 per 100,000	Fell to 210 per 100,000
MDG5.B: achieve universal access to reproductive health. *Pregnant women receiving adequate antenatal care visits*	35% in developing regions	Universal (100%)	Increased to 52%
MDG5.B: achieve universal access to reproductive health. *Women aged 15 – 49 in marriage/union, using contraceptives*	55% in developing regions	Universal (100%)	Increased to 64%
MDG6.A: halt and have started to reverse the spread of HIV/AIDS	3.5M new cases per year	0 new cases	2.1M new cases per year
MDG6.B: achieve global access to treatment for HIV/AIDS for those who need it by 2010	3% of people with HIV	100% of people with HIV	23% of people with HIV (2010) 45% of people with HIV (2015)
MDG6.C: ceased & started reversal of incidence of malaria & TB. *Incidence of malaria*	158 new cases per 1,000 at risk	Fewer than 158 new cases per 1,000 at risk	Fell to 94 new cases per 1,000 at risk
MDG6.C: ceased & started reversal of incidence of malaria & TB. *Incidence of tuberculosis (TB)*	172 new cases per 100,000 people	Fewer than 172 new cases per 100,000 people	Fell to 142 new cases per 100,000 people
MDG7.A: integrate principles of sustainable development into country policies & reverse loss of environmental resources			Multiple metrics (nearly all deteriorating)
MDG7.B: reduce biodiversity loss, achieving, by 2010, a significant reduction in the rate of loss			Red List Index shows continued biodiversity loss
MDG7.C: halve the proportion of the population without sustainable access to *safe drinking water*	24% without access to improved water source	Reduce to 12% without access	Fell to 9% without access
MDG7.C: halve the proportion of the population without sustainable access to *sanitation*	46% without access to improved sanitation	Reduce to 23% without access	Fell to 32% without access

*MDG8 (Global Partnership) does not have easily quantifiable targets and is therefore not included.

Source: United Nations (UN), the MDG Report (2015) & MDG Monitor.

The data visualization is available at OurWorldinData.org. There you will find further data on this topic.

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Critiques of Human Development

- **Fetishism of numbers**
  - The HDI risks reducing people-centred development to a technocratic measurement exercise, losing sight of deeper transformation
  - Do improvements in development indicators necessarily reflect real expansion of human capabilities?



In an area, around 50% of Class 5 students could *not* read a Class 2 level text; only 23.8% could do simple division. Despite enrollment and school infrastructure improvements, real learning remains weak.

Annual Status of Education Report (Rural) 2018
Provisional
January 15, 2019

Annual Status of Education Report
ASER 2018
Facilitated by PRATHAM

Critiques of Human Development

COMMENTARY

Hacking the Human Development Index: Why UNDP's Latest HDI Scores For India Are Misleading

SURAJ S
Feb 26, 2025, 04:46 PM | Updated Mar 03, 2025, 09:43 AM IST

Prefer



UNDP's Latest HDI Scores For India Are Misleading.

Poor Data Quality & Representation

For India, the data used in HDI is not representative in certain dimensions (regional disparities, outdated or coarse data). Thus the HDI may give a rosier picture than the lived reality in some regions.

See also: The limits of the UN's Planetary pressure-adjusted HDI (Hickel 2023)

Critiques of Human Development

- Adjunct to neoliberalism: giving structural adjustment or neoliberal reforms a “human face” (e.g., through basic needs or safety nets) often meant softening the effects of market liberalization rather than replacing it

Human development risks being reduced to business-as-usual with a human face



Jan Nederveen Pieterse

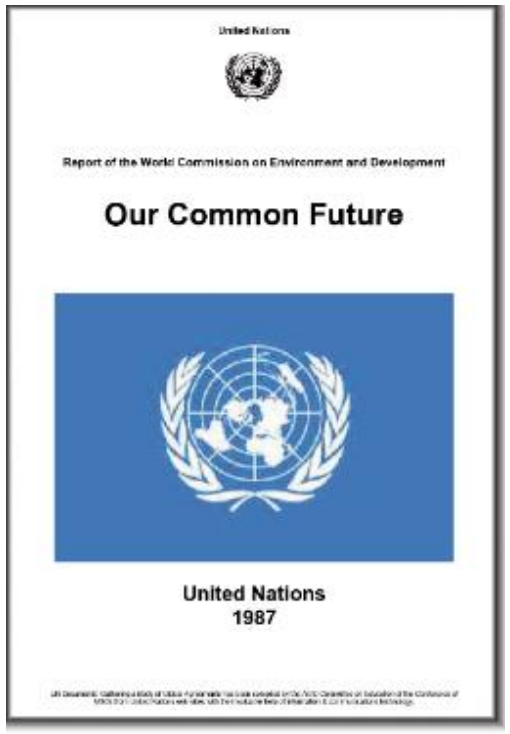
Paradigms	Who needs development?	How should it happen?	What is the importance?
Modernisation			
Dependency			
Neo-liberalism			
Developmental State			
Human development			
Sustainable development			
Post-development			

Any questions?

Sustainable Development



Gro Harlem Brundtland



- Sustainable development lacks a single definition.
- 'Development that meets the **needs** of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own **needs**'(Brundtland Commission 1987, 41).

Sustainable Development

- For sustainable development to be attained, “societies need to meet human **needs** both by increasing productive potential and by ensuring equitable opportunities for all” (Brundtland Commission 1987, 44)

- How does **'development'** contribute to the evolving concept of needs?
- ‘Needs’ are defined differently in different cultures



What Is To Be Sustained?

- Natural resources?
- The income generated from natural recourses?
- Production?
- Consumption?

Sustainable Development

- As a decision-making framework
- Sustainable development, as its name implies, would correct but not replace the existing international development model
- To ensure that development is also environmentally protective or restorative
- To offer an alternative to the binary “environment or development” narratives that have traditionally dominated public and private political discourse

Sustainable Development

- Rio+20, also known as the United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development, was the third international conference on sustainable development held in Rio de Janeiro in 2012, serving as a follow-up to the 1992 Earth Summit and the 2002 World Summit on Sustainable Development.



Rio+20 Summit "The Future We Want"

"We also reaffirm the need to achieve sustainable development by: promoting sustained, inclusive and equitable economic growth, creating greater opportunities for all, reducing inequalities, raising basic standards of living; fostering equitable social development and inclusion; and promoting integrated and sustainable management of natural resources and ecosystems that supports inter alia economic, social and human development while facilitating ecosystem conservation, regeneration and restoration and resilience in the face of new and emerging challenges" (UN General Assembly 2012, para. 4)



Sustainable Development Goals



"[The SDGs] should address and incorporate in a balanced way all three dimensions of sustainable development and their inter-linkages . . . We also underscore that SDGs should be action-oriented, concise and easy to communicate, limited in number, aspirational, global in nature and universally applicable to all countries while taking into account different national realities, capacities and levels of development and respecting national policies and priorities . . . Governments should drive implementation [of the SDGs] with the active involvement of all relevant stakeholders, as appropriate" (UN General Assembly 2012, paras. 246–7)

Any question?


SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS
17 GOALS TO TRANSFORM OUR WORLD
1 NO POVERTY
2 ZERO HUNGER
3 GOOD HEALTH AND WELL-BEING
4 QUALITY EDUCATION
5 GENDER EQUALITY
6 CLEAN WATER AND SANITATION
7 AFFORDABLE AND CLEAN ENERGY
8 DECENT WORK AND ECONOMIC GROWTH
9 INDUSTRY, INNOVATION AND INFRASTRUCTURE
10 REDUCED INEQUALITIES
11 SUSTAINABLE CITIES AND COMMUNITIES
12 RESPONSIBLE CONSUMPTION AND PRODUCTION
13 CLIMATE ACTION
14 LIFE BELOW WATER
15 LIFE ON LAND
16 PEACE, JUSTICE AND STRONG INSTITUTIONS
17 PARTNERSHIPS FOR THE GOALS
SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS

Quick question

Visit the UN's SDGs website, read about the 17 goals (and their targets), and respond to the following questions in a single reply.

Question 1: How closely do the SDGs align with Amartya Sen's concept of 'Development as Freedom'?

Question 2: To what extent do the SDGs exhibit coherence in their objectives and actions?

You'll have 15 minutes to think and organize.

If you're comfortable, I encourage you to share your answer verbally with the class.

If you prefer, you can type your response. Remember to provide your name and student number. I'll also read out some responses.

https://app.sli.do/event/s3gXyj8UEXLCyjhfqRFTkE



Criticisms of SDGs

- Enforce a weak sustainability
- Failure to reconcile growth and sustainability
- Ignore inequality

The SDG proposals are not just unrealistic but undemocratic, since the goals are to be realised by growing gross domestic product (GDP), increasing market liberalisation and free trade, as well as according more power to the World Trade Organization.

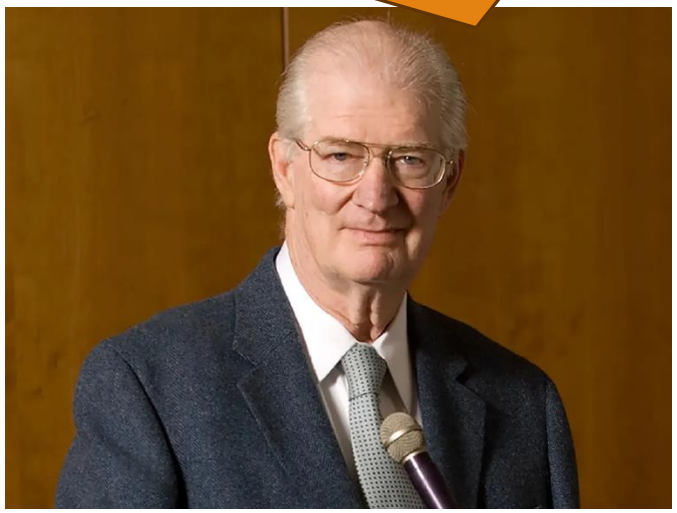


Ariel Salleh, feminist scholar

Critiques of Sustainable Development

- Technocentric
- Ethnocentric
- Capitalisation and commodification of nature
- Sustaining development rather than developing sustainability

The term sustainable growth should be rejected as a bad oxymoron.



Herman Daly, a former World Bank economist

Paradigms	Who needs development?	How should it happen?	What is the importance?
Modernisation			
Dependency			
Neo-liberalism			
Developmental State			
Human development			
Sustainable development			
Post-development			

Conclusion

- Human development theory shifted the focus of planners away from national-level priorities, introducing new theoretical foundations for understanding development and highlighting new areas of focus.
- This required states and aid agencies to adopt different approaches to development.
- However, it left the private sector largely unaffected. A similar issue arises in the context of discussions about sustainable development.

Conclusion

- Sustainable development, as a policy framework, serves as a platform for international discussions on how ‘development’ should be achieved.
- Yet, it has not fully addressed the fundamental question of what sustainability truly means within this framework (i.e., what is to be sustained)
- Is sustainable development essentially a way to humanise neoliberalism?

Quiz 1 (via Canvas)

Rubrics

Quality of Argument

Structure of Argument

Evidence of Subject Knowledge

Instructions

Venue: LI 4208

Answer all questions.

This is a closed-book quiz. No notes, textbooks, or online resources are allowed.

Arrive 5-10 mins in advance as the test will start at 9am sharp.

Late arrivals may still take the exam but will not receive extra time.

Put your student ID on the table for taking attendance.

Week 5: Agents of Development

Essential Readings

Li, T. M. (2007) 'Introduction' in *The Will to Improve: Governmentality, Development, and the Practice of Politics*. London: Duke University Press.

Sondarjee, M. (2021). 'Change and stability at the World Bank: inclusive practices and neoliberal technocratic rationality', *Third World Quarterly*, 42(2), pp. 348–365.

Supplementary Readings

Kothari, U. (2005) 'Authority and Expertise: The Professionalisation of International Development and the Ordering of Dissent', *Antipode*, 37(3), pp. 425–446.